

BRITISH INDIA: A STRUCTURED HISTORY

1757–1947

A 15-page knowledge document designed for retrieval-augmented generation (RAG), semantic search, and document chunking.

Scope: political history, administration, economy, society, reform, nationalism, constitutional change, and independence.

Note: The term “British India” is used broadly here for the period of expanding British political control in the Indian subcontinent. British-administered territories and princely states had different constitutional positions, so they are distinguished where relevant.

1. Before British Dominance: The Mughal and Regional Order

When European trading companies expanded in India, the subcontinent was not a political vacuum. The Mughal Empire remained an important imperial framework in the eighteenth century, while regional powers such as the Marathas, Mysore, Hyderabad, Bengal, Awadh, and the Sikh polity exercised substantial authority. The decline of centralized Mughal power created a competitive political environment in which regional rulers, military commanders, bankers, merchants, and European companies could form shifting alliances.

The English East India Company began as a commercial organization. Its early settlements were concentrated around ports, including Surat, Madras, Bombay, and Calcutta. Company officials initially depended on permissions from Indian rulers and negotiated privileges for trade. The Company's transformation from merchant to territorial power occurred gradually through warfare, diplomacy, revenue collection, and intervention in succession disputes.

The East India Company

The English East India Company was chartered in 1600. Over time it developed fortified settlements and private military forces. Competition with other European companies, especially the French, encouraged the Company to become involved in Indian politics. The Carnatic Wars in the eighteenth century demonstrated how European military organizations could influence regional conflicts.

A major turning point came in Bengal. The Battle of Plassey in 1757 placed the Company in a much stronger political position in Bengal after the defeat of Siraj-ud-daulah and his allies. The Battle of Buxar in 1764 further strengthened Company authority. In 1765, the Mughal emperor granted the Company the diwani, or right to collect revenue, in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa.

Why Bengal mattered

- Bengal was one of the wealthiest regions in the subcontinent and generated substantial land revenue.
- Revenue resources helped finance the Company's military expansion.
- Company political authority increasingly became connected with taxation and administration.
- The Company's commercial interests and territorial responsibilities became difficult to separate.

The Company's rise therefore represented a transition from European trading presence to territorial rule. This transition also created new administrative problems, including corruption, revenue extraction, military expenditure, and the need to govern a large population.

2. Company Rule and the Creation of a Colonial State

After acquiring revenue-collecting rights, the East India Company faced the challenge of governing territories on an unprecedented scale. The British Parliament increasingly intervened in Company affairs. The Regulating Act of 1773 created greater parliamentary oversight, while the Charter Act of 1833 strengthened the centralizing tendencies of Company administration. The Government of India Act of 1858 later transferred authority from the Company to the British Crown.

Warren Hastings and early administration

Warren Hastings served as the first Governor-General of Bengal under the Regulating Act. His administration attempted to establish more systematic revenue, judicial, and political arrangements. British officials frequently relied on Indian intermediaries and existing legal traditions, but they also introduced institutions that gradually altered the structure of government.

Cornwallis and administrative reform

Lord Cornwallis introduced reforms associated with the Permanent Settlement of Bengal in 1793. Under this system, zamindars were recognized as landholders responsible for paying fixed revenue to the colonial state. The settlement produced a new relationship among the state, landlords, and cultivators. Its effects differed across regions and became an important part of the history of colonial land revenue.

The Company also developed a hierarchy of civil and military officials. European officials occupied senior positions, while Indians were employed extensively at subordinate levels. The Indian Civil Service eventually became the principal elite administrative institution of British rule.

Expansion through diplomacy and war

British territorial expansion took several forms. Military victories brought some territories under direct rule. Subsidiary alliances required Indian rulers to accept British military arrangements and restrictions on foreign policy. The Doctrine of Lapse, associated with Governor-General Lord Dalhousie, was used to annex certain princely states where adopted heirs were not recognized for succession purposes. Satara, Jhansi, and Nagpur were among the states annexed under this policy.

British rule therefore developed through multiple mechanisms rather than a single conquest. By the mid-nineteenth century, the Company controlled large areas directly and exercised paramount influence over many princely states.

3. Economy, Land Revenue, and Trade

Colonial rule reshaped the Indian economy through taxation, trade policy, infrastructure, and the integration of Indian production into global markets. Economic historians disagree on the scale and mechanisms of economic change, but there is broad agreement that colonial institutions significantly altered patterns of production, commerce, and distribution.

Land revenue systems

Three major revenue arrangements are commonly discussed: the Permanent Settlement, the Ryotwari system, and the Mahalwari system. The Permanent Settlement was prominent in Bengal. Ryotwari settlements, associated with administrators such as Thomas Munro, dealt more directly with individual cultivators in large parts of southern and western India. Mahalwari arrangements were used in parts of northern India and treated village communities or estates as units for revenue assessment.

Revenue demands could be substantial and were linked to agricultural conditions, market prices, and administrative assessments. Failure to meet obligations could lead to loss of land or indebtedness. Commercial credit therefore became increasingly important in rural society.

Trade and deindustrialization

India had a major textile and handicraft sector before the nineteenth century. The expansion of British manufactured textiles, changes in tariff policy, and the restructuring of global trade reduced the relative position of many traditional textile producers. At the same time, some Indian industries adapted and new commercial groups emerged.

Colonial trade also encouraged production of commodities such as cotton, indigo, opium, tea, jute, and other export-oriented goods. These crops connected Indian agriculture to international markets but could increase vulnerability to price fluctuations and local shortages.

Drain of wealth debate

Indian nationalist thinkers, especially Dadabhai Naoroji, argued that a significant portion of India's economic resources was transferred abroad without an equivalent return. Naoroji called this the "drain of wealth" and used it as a major critique of colonial rule. Later economic historians have debated the measurement, composition, and effects of these transfers.

Railways and infrastructure

The British constructed extensive railways, telegraph lines, roads, ports, and canals. These systems facilitated military movement, administration, and commercial exchange. Railways also helped create a more integrated Indian market and enabled people, ideas, and political organizations to move across regions. Infrastructure therefore had both colonial purposes and long-term consequences for Indian economic and political integration.

4. Society, Education, and Cultural Change

British rule affected Indian society through education, law, missionary activity, print culture, urbanization, and administrative classification. These changes interacted with existing social institutions rather than simply replacing them.

Education

The British established schools, colleges, and universities, while Christian missionaries and Indian reformers also developed educational institutions. The English-language education system produced a new group of Indians familiar with European political thought, liberalism, constitutionalism, science, and modern professions. The universities of Calcutta, Bombay, and Madras were established in 1857.

English education was limited in reach for much of the population, and access varied by class, caste, gender, and region. Nevertheless, educated Indians became increasingly important in journalism, law, administration, social reform, and nationalist politics.

Social reform

Social reform movements emerged from both Indian and colonial initiatives. Raja Rammohan Roy campaigned against practices he regarded as harmful and supported modern education. The abolition of sati was enacted in Bengal in 1829 under Governor-General William Bentinck. Later reformers addressed widow remarriage, child marriage, caste discrimination, women's education, and religious reform.

The Hindu Widows' Remarriage Act of 1856 legalized widow remarriage under specified conditions. The Age of Consent Act of 1891 raised the legally recognized age of consent for girls. Reform debates were often contentious because they involved questions of religion, community identity, colonial authority, and social custom.

Print and public debate

Printing presses, newspapers, journals, pamphlets, and literary societies expanded public discussion. Indian-language newspapers became important platforms for political and social debate. The colonial government sometimes restricted the press, especially during periods of political unrest.

Classification and census

Colonial administrators increasingly classified populations by religion, caste, tribe, language, and occupation. Census operations beginning in the nineteenth century created large administrative datasets. Historians have debated how far these categories reflected existing identities and how far they hardened or reshaped social boundaries.

5. The Revolt of 1857 and the End of Company Rule

The uprising of 1857 was the most serious challenge to Company rule before independence. It began among Indian soldiers, or sepoys, in the Bengal Army and spread to several regions of northern and central India. Causes included military grievances, political annexations, land and revenue pressures, social tensions, and fears about religious interference.

Immediate trigger

A widely remembered immediate issue involved the new Enfield rifle cartridges, which soldiers believed were greased with animal fat offensive to both Hindu and Muslim religious practices. The cartridge controversy became a powerful symbol of wider distrust. The uprising began at Meerut in May 1857 and quickly reached Delhi.

Major centers and leaders

- Delhi: Bahadur Shah II became a symbolic figurehead for the rebels.
- Kanpur: Nana Sahib became associated with the uprising there.
- Lucknow: Begum Hazrat Mahal played an important role in resistance.
- Jhansi: Rani Lakshmibai became a prominent military leader.
- Bihar: Kunwar Singh led resistance in the region.

The revolt did not encompass all of India. Large parts of southern India, the Punjab, and many princely states remained outside the main rebellion, and some Indian soldiers and rulers supported the British. British forces eventually suppressed the uprising by 1858.

Consequences

The Government of India Act 1858 ended the rule of the East India Company and transferred authority to the British Crown. The office of Secretary of State for India was created in London, while the Governor-General also became the Viceroy, representing the Crown.

The British reorganized the army, altered recruitment patterns, and became more cautious about intervening in religious and social practices. The revolt also became a powerful memory in later Indian nationalism. British and Indian interpretations of 1857 differed sharply: British accounts often described it as a mutiny, while many later Indian nationalists interpreted it as an early war of independence.

6. Crown Rule and the Growth of Indian Nationalism

After 1858, the British Crown ruled India through the Viceroy and an expanding administrative structure. The colonial government combined centralized authority with indirect rule over princely states. At the same time, new political organizations emerged among educated Indians.

Formation of the Indian National Congress

The Indian National Congress was founded in 1885. Early Congress leaders included Dadabhai Naoroji, Surendranath Banerjee, Pherozeshah Mehta, Gopal Krishna Gokhale, and others. The early organization used petitions, speeches, resolutions, and constitutional methods to demand greater Indian participation in government.

Early nationalist demands included expansion of legislative councils, greater access for Indians to higher administrative positions, reduction of excessive military expenditure, and economic reforms. Naoroji's economic critique argued that colonial governance contributed to a transfer of resources from India to Britain.

Moderates and assertive nationalism

The Congress's early leadership is often described as moderate because it emphasized constitutional pressure and gradual reform. By the early twentieth century, more assertive leaders such as Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Bipin Chandra Pal, and Lala Lajpat Rai promoted mass political mobilization and stronger demands for self-government.

The Partition of Bengal

In 1905, Viceroy Lord Curzon announced the partition of Bengal. The government presented administrative efficiency as a rationale, while many Indian nationalists interpreted the measure as an attempt to weaken political opposition. The partition triggered the Swadeshi movement, which encouraged the use of Indian-made goods and boycotts of British goods.

The partition was reversed in 1911. The controversy contributed to the growth of mass politics, economic nationalism, and political organizations based partly on religious and regional identities.

7. Political Organizations, Muslim Politics, and Constitutional Reform

Indian political life became more diverse in the early twentieth century. The All-India Muslim League was founded in 1906 at Dhaka. It initially sought political safeguards and representation for Muslims within the colonial constitutional system.

Morley–Minto reforms

The Indian Councils Act of 1909 expanded legislative councils and introduced separate electorates for Muslims. Separate electorates meant that members of a particular community could vote for representatives designated for that community. This arrangement became an important and controversial feature of colonial constitutional politics.

Lucknow Pact

In 1916, the Congress and Muslim League reached the Lucknow Pact, agreeing on a set of constitutional demands and representation arrangements. The agreement demonstrated that cooperation between major political organizations was possible, although it did not permanently resolve differences.

Montagu–Chelmsford reforms

The Government of India Act 1919 introduced dyarchy in the provinces. Certain subjects were transferred to Indian ministers while other areas remained under the authority of officials responsible to the governor. The act also expanded legislative representation, though voting rights remained restricted.

The reforms did not satisfy nationalist demands for responsible government. Political mobilization increased after the First World War, particularly under Mahatma Gandhi.

The Rowlatt Acts and Jallianwala Bagh

The Rowlatt legislation of 1919 extended extraordinary powers to the colonial government for dealing with revolutionary activity. Protests followed across India. On 13 April 1919, troops under Brigadier-General Reginald Dyer fired on a gathering at Jallianwala Bagh in Amritsar, killing and injuring large numbers of people. The exact casualty figures vary across sources and definitions.

The event had a profound effect on Indian political opinion and became a major turning point in the relationship between the colonial state and nationalist movements.

8. Gandhi and Mass Nationalism

Mahatma Gandhi transformed nationalist politics by combining political campaigns with mass participation, nonviolent resistance, and civil disobedience. His methods drew on Indian traditions as well as ideas associated with moral resistance.

Non-Cooperation Movement

The Non-Cooperation Movement began in 1920 in the context of opposition to colonial policies and the Khilafat issue. Supporters were encouraged to boycott certain government institutions, educational institutions, titles, and imported goods. The movement drew large numbers of participants but was withdrawn by Gandhi in 1922 after violence at Chauri Chaura.

Civil Disobedience and the Salt March

The Civil Disobedience Movement began in 1930. Gandhi's Salt March from Sabarmati Ashram to Dandi challenged the colonial salt laws. Salt was symbolically important because the tax affected a basic necessity. Civil disobedience campaigns spread across India and involved arrests, boycotts, and protests.

The Gandhi-Irwin Pact of 1931 led to Gandhi's participation in the Second Round Table Conference in London. Constitutional negotiations continued, but disagreements over representation and the structure of government remained.

Quit India Movement

In August 1942, the Congress launched the Quit India Movement demanding an end to British rule. The colonial government quickly arrested major Congress leaders. Despite repression and decentralized resistance, the movement demonstrated the breadth of opposition to colonial rule during the Second World War.

Limits and diversity of nationalism

Indian nationalism was never a single movement with identical goals. Congress nationalists, revolutionaries, socialists, communal organizations, peasant movements, labor organizations, Dalit political movements, and princely-state reformers had different priorities. Leaders such as B. R. Ambedkar emphasized social equality and political safeguards for historically oppressed communities.

9. Revolutionary Movements, Workers, Peasants, and Social Politics

Alongside constitutional politics and Gandhian campaigns, revolutionary groups challenged British rule through armed action and clandestine organization. Examples include the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association and revolutionary networks in Bengal and Punjab. Bhagat Singh became one of the best-known revolutionary figures and was executed in 1931.

Revolutionary politics

Revolutionaries generally argued that colonial rule could not be ended through petitions alone. Their activities included political assassinations, bomb attacks, propaganda, and attempts to organize armed resistance. Some revolutionary groups later incorporated socialist ideas.

Workers and trade unions

Industrialization in cities such as Bombay, Calcutta, Madras, Kanpur, and Ahmedabad produced expanding working-class communities. Labor organizations campaigned over wages, working hours, and working conditions. The All India Trade Union Congress was founded in 1920.

Peasant movements

Agrarian movements arose around revenue demands, rents, indebtedness, forced cultivation, and landlord practices. The Indigo revolt in Bengal in 1859–60 opposed coercive indigo cultivation. Later movements included Champaran, Kheda, Bardoli, and the Tebhaga movement. These movements connected rural economic grievances with wider political mobilization.

Ambedkar and social democracy

B. R. Ambedkar emerged as a major advocate for the political and social rights of Dalits, then widely referred to by colonial and contemporary terminology as the Depressed Classes. He argued that political independence without social equality would leave entrenched forms of discrimination intact. His negotiations with Gandhi over separate electorates contributed to the Poona Pact of 1932.

The diversity of political movements is essential to understanding late colonial India. Independence resulted not from one organization alone but from multiple pressures, negotiations, mass movements, constitutional developments, wartime changes, and transformations in British politics.

10. Government of India Act 1935 and Provincial Politics

The Government of India Act 1935 was the most extensive constitutional measure introduced by the British Parliament before independence. It proposed a federation of British Indian provinces and princely states, although the federal part was never fully implemented. Provincial autonomy became a central feature.

Provincial autonomy

Elections were held in 1937 under the new constitutional framework. The Indian National Congress formed ministries in several provinces. The Muslim League sought to expand its political base and argued increasingly for safeguards and representation for Muslims.

Congress ministries resigned in 1939 after the Viceroy declared India at war with Germany without consulting elected Indian leaders. The political consequences of this decision contributed to growing Congress–League disagreement.

Muslim League and the Lahore Resolution

Under Muhammad Ali Jinnah, the Muslim League became increasingly influential. In March 1940, the League adopted the Lahore Resolution, which called for geographically contiguous Muslim-majority areas in the northwest and east to be constituted into “independent states,” with autonomous and sovereign units. The later political interpretation of this resolution became associated with the demand for Pakistan.

World War II

India became involved in the Second World War after the British declaration of war in September 1939. India contributed soldiers, labor, resources, and industrial production to the Allied war effort. The war placed enormous economic and administrative pressures on the colony.

The Bengal famine of 1943 caused catastrophic loss of life. Historians have debated the relative importance of food availability, wartime procurement, inflation, transport disruptions, market failures, administrative decisions, and other factors. The famine became a major indictment of wartime governance.

11. Subhas Chandra Bose and the Indian National Army

Subhas Chandra Bose was a prominent nationalist leader who differed from Gandhi and other Congress leaders over strategy and the pace of independence. He was elected Congress president in 1938 and 1939 but resigned after conflict with the Congress leadership.

During the Second World War, Bose sought international assistance against British rule. He eventually reached Southeast Asia and became associated with the Indian National Army (INA), which had been formed from Indian prisoners of war and expatriates in the region. Bose reorganized the INA and established the Provisional Government of Free India in 1943.

INA military campaign

The INA fought alongside Japanese forces during the Burma campaign and participated in the 1944 offensive toward northeastern India. The campaign failed to achieve its military objectives, and the INA was eventually defeated as Japanese forces retreated.

INA trials

After the war, the British tried INA officers at the Red Fort in Delhi. The trials generated widespread public interest and political mobilization in India. Congress leaders and other political groups defended the accused officers, even though their organizations had different views of Bose's wartime alliances.

Royal Indian Navy mutiny

In February 1946, ratings of the Royal Indian Navy in Bombay and elsewhere rebelled against poor conditions and discriminatory treatment. The unrest spread to other naval establishments and received sympathy from sections of the public and political organizations. The episode was short-lived but demonstrated the difficulty of maintaining unquestioned loyalty within the armed forces during the final phase of British rule.

The INA experience and the 1946 naval uprising became part of the broader context in which British officials assessed the feasibility and cost of continuing colonial rule. They were not, by themselves, the sole cause of British withdrawal.

12. Constitutional Negotiations, Cabinet Mission, and Partition

After the Second World War, Britain faced major economic pressures and a changed international environment. The Labour government elected in 1945 under Prime Minister Clement Attlee supported a transfer of power, while negotiations with Indian political organizations focused on the structure of the future state.

Simla Conference

The 1945 Simla Conference attempted to establish an executive council with broader Indian representation. Disagreement over the representation of Muslims contributed to its failure.

Cabinet Mission Plan

The Cabinet Mission arrived in India in 1946 and proposed a constitutional arrangement designed to preserve Indian unity while allowing substantial provincial autonomy. It recommended a weak central authority dealing mainly with defense, foreign affairs, and communications, alongside groupings of provinces.

The Congress and Muslim League initially accepted parts of the plan but later disagreed over how the proposed grouping system would operate. Political tensions increased substantially during 1946.

Direct Action and communal violence

The Muslim League called for Direct Action Day on 16 August 1946. Serious communal violence followed in Calcutta and later spread to other areas. Violence occurred among multiple communities and took different forms across regions. The scale of killing, displacement, and destruction created an increasingly unstable political environment.

Mountbatten and the transfer of power

Lord Mountbatten became Viceroy in March 1947. The British government concluded that power should be transferred rapidly. The Indian Independence Act 1947 created the independent dominions of India and Pakistan. Independence was brought forward to August 1947.

The boundary between the new states was determined by the Radcliffe Boundary Commissions. The boundaries were announced after independence, contributing to uncertainty and large-scale population movement.

13. Partition and Independence in 1947

India became independent on 15 August 1947, while Pakistan became independent on 14 August. Independence ended British sovereignty over British India, but it was accompanied by one of the largest and most traumatic episodes of forced migration in modern history.

Migration

Millions of Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs crossed the new borders in both directions. Punjab experienced particularly intense violence and displacement. Bengal also underwent large-scale migration, although the pattern and timing differed from Punjab.

Estimates of deaths during Partition vary widely because records were incomplete and violence occurred across a vast region. Scholarly estimates commonly place the death toll in the hundreds of thousands to around a million or more, while estimates of displaced people run into the many millions.

Princely states

The end of British paramountcy left princely states to decide their relationship with the new dominions. Most eventually acceded to India or Pakistan, although several cases—including Hyderabad, Junagadh, and Jammu and Kashmir—produced significant political and military disputes.

Legal end of British rule

The Indian Independence Act 1947 legally ended British authority over the two new dominions. India continued initially under the Government of India Act 1935 with adaptations until it adopted its Constitution in 1950. Pakistan followed a separate constitutional path.

Legacy

The colonial period left enduring institutions and infrastructure, including parliamentary procedures, civil services, railways, universities, legal institutions, military structures, and administrative boundaries. It also left major legacies of economic inequality, communal politics, land conflicts, social hierarchies, and debates over the nature of the colonial economy.

The history of British India therefore cannot be reduced to either a simple story of modernization or a simple story of extraction. Its institutions produced both long-term capacities and deep social and economic disruptions, and their effects remain subjects of historical debate.

14. Key Institutions, Acts, Movements, and Terms

Major constitutional and administrative milestones

- 1773 – Regulating Act: increased parliamentary oversight of the East India Company and created the office of Governor-General of Bengal.
- 1784 – Pitt's India Act: strengthened British government control over Company political affairs.
- 1793 – Permanent Settlement: established a major land revenue arrangement in Bengal.
- 1813 – Charter Act: ended the Company's monopoly over most Indian trade while retaining important exceptions.
- 1833 – Charter Act: further centralized administration and ended the Company's commercial role.
- 1853 – Charter Act: expanded legislative functions and altered civil service recruitment arrangements.
- 1857 – Revolt: major uprising against Company rule.
- 1858 – Government of India Act: transferred rule from the Company to the Crown.
- 1909 – Indian Councils Act: expanded councils and introduced separate electorates for Muslims.
- 1919 – Government of India Act: introduced provincial dyarchy and expanded legislative representation.
- 1935 – Government of India Act: introduced provincial autonomy and proposed a federation.
- 1947 – Indian Independence Act: created the independent dominions of India and Pakistan.

Major movements

- Swadeshi Movement – boycott and promotion of indigenous goods after the 1905 partition of Bengal.
- Home Rule Movement – campaign for self-government associated with Annie Besant and Bal Gangadhar Tilak.
- Non-Cooperation Movement – mass anti-colonial campaign launched in 1920.
- Civil Disobedience Movement – campaign beginning in 1930, strongly associated with the Salt March.
- Quit India Movement – 1942 campaign demanding an end to British rule.

Important terms

- Diwani – right to collect land revenue and certain related revenues.
- Zamindar – landholder/intermediary recognized within several colonial revenue arrangements.
- Ryotwari – revenue system in which the state dealt more directly with individual cultivators.
- Mahalwari – revenue arrangement based around villages or estates in parts of northern India.
- Princely state – Indian state ruled by a hereditary monarch under British paramountcy rather than direct British administration.
- Viceroy – Crown representative in India after the transfer of power from the Company to the British Crown.
- Swaraj – self-rule; a central political concept in Indian nationalism.
- Swadeshi – use and promotion of locally produced goods, associated with economic nationalism.
- Separate electorate – electoral system in which voters of a specified community elected representatives allocated to that community.

15. RAG-Oriented Timeline and Knowledge Map

Chronological timeline

- 1600** — English East India Company receives its charter.
- 1757** — Battle of Plassey strengthens Company influence in Bengal.
- 1764** — Battle of Buxar.
- 1765** — Company receives diwani rights in Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa.
- 1773** — Regulating Act establishes stronger parliamentary oversight.
- 1793** — Permanent Settlement introduced in Bengal.
- 1813** — Charter Act changes the Company's trade monopoly.
- 1833** — Charter Act centralizes administration and ends Company commercial functions.
- 1857** — Major revolt against Company rule begins.
- 1858** — Government of India Act transfers authority to the British Crown.
- 1885** — Indian National Congress founded.
- 1905** — Partition of Bengal; Swadeshi movement expands.
- 1906** — All-India Muslim League founded.
- 1909** — Morley–Minto reforms introduce separate electorates for Muslims.
- 1919** — Government of India Act; Jallianwala Bagh massacre.
- 1920–22** — Non-Cooperation Movement.
- 1930** — Salt March and Civil Disobedience Movement.
- 1932** — Poona Pact.
- 1935** — Government of India Act.
- 1937** — Provincial elections under the 1935 Act.
- 1940** — Lahore Resolution.
- 1942** — Quit India Movement.
- 1943** — Bengal famine reaches catastrophic scale.
- 1945** — Second World War ends; constitutional negotiations intensify.
- 1946** — Cabinet Mission; communal violence; Royal Indian Navy uprising.
- 1947** — Indian Independence Act; India and Pakistan become independent.

Useful RAG chunk topics

- East India Company: commercial organization to territorial power
- Bengal: Plassey, Buxar, diwani, revenue administration
- Colonial economy: land revenue, trade, textiles, exports, drain theory
- Social change: education, reform movements, print culture, census
- 1857 revolt: causes, leaders, regional spread, consequences
- Crown rule: Viceroy, civil service, army, princely states
- Indian nationalism: Congress, Swadeshi, constitutional reform
- Gandhian movements: Non-Cooperation, Civil Disobedience, Quit India
- Muslim League: formation, constitutional demands, Lahore Resolution
- World War II: Indian participation, famine, political consequences
- INA and Bose: wartime nationalism and post-war trials
- 1946–47: Cabinet Mission, communal violence, Mountbatten Plan
- Partition: independence, migration, violence, princely states

Suggested metadata fields for chunking

For a RAG pipeline, useful metadata can include: period, year, topic, region, political institution, movement, person, event type, and source section. Keeping each chunk semantically coherent—for

example, one chunk on the Permanent Settlement and another on the 1857 revolt—can improve retrieval compared with splitting solely by character count.